

» AVANI LEKHARA

Category: Shooting (Women's 10m Air Rifle Standing SH1)

Avani Lekhara made history at the Paris Paralympics by becoming the first Indian to successfully defend her Paralympic title, winning gold in the Women's 10m Air Rifle Standing SH1 category. She improved upon her previous Paralympic record from Tokyo, where she scored 249.6, with a remarkable 249.7 in Paris.

Born in Jaipur, Avani was left paralysed from the waist down after a car accident. Her father, Praveen, played a pivotal role in her recovery, encouraging her to explore sports as a means of physical and mental rehabilitation. She initially tried archery and swimming before discovering her passion for shooting at a local range.

Inspired by Olympic gold medalist Abhinav Bindra, Avani's dedication paid off as she won both gold in the 10m Air Rifle SH1 and bronze in the 50m rifle 3 positions SH1 during her debut Paralympic campaign in Tokyo. She became the first Indian woman to win a Paralympic gold and the first to secure multiple medals at the Games.

Alongside her athletic achievements, Avani has managed to balance her training with her pursuit of a law degree. Her success in Tokyo also earned her an out-of-turn appointment as Assistant Conservator of Forests by the Government of Rajasthan.

In the lead-up to the Paris Paralympics, Avani faced challenges, including a recurring gallbladder issue that required surgery, sidelining her for a month and a half during the final stretch of her preparation. Despite this, she triumphed once again.

Currently ranked fourth in the world, Avani has also won gold at the Hangzhou Asian Para Games, along with numerous accolades from Para World Cup events.

